

In a world of dynamic changes, Bhalla says he has seen this shift earlier with strategy and digital roles, and believes AI is following a similar pattern. “Only a small number of companies will create dedicated AI leadership roles at the top. For most, AI capability will be embedded into mainstream business leadership, with technology leaders enabling the shift and business leaders owning the transformation,” he adds.

Mitra says this shift is already changing how leaders are prepared on the ground. He adds that leading organisations are also rethinking how they track and evaluate leadership readiness.

HIDDEN GAPS

Organisations often overestimate how ready the successors chosen by the companies are.

Experience is necessary, but it is only the entry ticket. “Many organisations still equate tenure, domain expertise, or P&L exposure with readiness for the top job, when senior leadership demands something much broader. What matters most at that level is leadership maturity, judgment, gravitas, resilience, and the ability to align stakeholders through uncertainty,” says Bhalla. He adds that the deeper issue is understated. “The more uncomfortable truth is that many companies are not just misjudging readiness, they are overstating it.”

“The gap is usually visible, but not acted on because confronting it can unsettle the incumbent or force difficult succession decisions earlier than the organisation wants,” he notes.

FAMILY VS CORPORATE PROCESS

Succession planning in India, particularly within family-led enterprises, often operates in silence unspoken, informal, and deferred.

As Rajiv Gupta, Chairperson, School of Family Business, Masters Union, puts it, “Ask any promoter what happens if something happens to them tomorrow. That silence is the answer. In most cases, that silence itself is the succession plan.”

While professional firms at least articulate succession through frameworks and policies, family businesses often bypass formalisation altogether. Succession is assumed rather than designed, typically following traditional inheritance patterns.

Across both models, successors are often protected rather than tested, leaving readiness presumed rather than proven. What works, according to Gupta, is far more deliberate. Structured job rotations, mandatory identification and early development of successors, and critically a system that rewards leaders for build-



“High-potential leaders are unwilling to wait indefinitely for the top role. You can’t expect someone who is ready to be a CEO to sit in line”

MARK BRAITHWAITE
MANAGING DIRECTOR—
ASIA PACIFIC, ODGERS



“The ability to connect technology, customer, and commercial outcomes is critical, and this is where many pipelines fall short”

SUMIT MITRA
CEO, TESCO BUSINESS
SOLUTIONS

ing replacements rather than penalising them.

Ultimately succession must be owned at the very top. Without CEO or promoter-level commitment, it risks becoming a compliance exercise. Even with structure, intent can falter.

In most cases, though, succession failure extends beyond governance. It impacts employees, destabilises organisations, and ripples across the broader ecosystem. As Gupta frames it, leadership transition is less about planning for replacement and more about building continuity before it is urgently needed.

The question is not ‘who is next?’ It’s whether anyone is truly ready when it matters. **BT**